Incident Report INC-0312: Payment processing delays

Date: 2026-03-05
Severity: SEV-1
Status: Resolved
Incident commander: Nino Beridze

Summary
Between 09:47 and 12:59 UTC on 2026-03-05 (duration 3 hours 12 minutes) payment processing was severely delayed. About 18,400 payments were delayed by more than 60 seconds and 312 payments failed and had to be retried by merchants.

Root cause
Change CHG-2031, deployed on 2026-03-03, reduced the payments-db connection pool of payment-gateway from 200 to 20 connections. Load was low on 2026-03-03 and 2026-03-04, so the problem stayed hidden. At the morning peak on 2026-03-05 request threads waited for database connections, requests queued and timed out.

Impact
payment-gateway: requests timed out or were delayed (primary impact).
ledger-service: the ledger-events backlog reached 41,000 events and ledger postings were delayed by up to 2 hours.
notification-service: payment receipts were sent late.
fraud-scoring was not affected. The TLS certificate rotation CHG-2034 was investigated and ruled out because the new certificates were valid and fraud-scoring latency stayed normal.

Mitigation
At 12:40 UTC the pool size was raised to 120 by hand. The permanent fix CHG-2042 set the pool size to 150 on 2026-03-12.

Contributing factors
There was no alert on the db_pool_wait_ms metric. The change review for CHG-2031 did not include a load test.